

Belgium Itinerary

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Contents

- Bruges: 366 Belfry Steps, Canal Mist & a Medieval City That Belongs to You After Dark

Bruges: 366 Belfry Steps, Canal Mist & a Medieval City That Belongs to You After Dark

We arrived in **Bruges** by train from Brussels on a grey October afternoon, wheeled our bags ten minutes through cobbled lanes, and walked straight into a city that looks almost exactly the way it looked in 1500. That is not a marketing line — it is a literal fact of urban planning. Bruges was a wealthy medieval trading port, its harbour silted up, the money left, and the city quietly fossilised. For five centuries almost nothing was demolished. Step into the centre and you are walking through a preserved Flemish town that the rest of Europe paved over.

The cliché is that Bruges is the "Venice of the North." It is not. Venice is louder, hotter, more theatrical. Bruges is smaller, softer, more domestic — a city of gabled houses, slow brown canals, swans, bell towers, and people on bicycles ringing little bells at you. It is also, between roughly 11 a.m. and 5 p.m., absolutely overrun with day-trip coaches from Brussels and the Channel ports. We will get to that. The short version: stay overnight. Everything depends on staying overnight.

Day 1

Markt Square & the 366 Steps of the Belfort

The **Markt** — the main square — is the postcard image: a long open piazza ringed by tall, narrow, candy-coloured guild houses with stepped gables, dominated at one end by the looming brick bulk of the **Belfort**, the 83-metre medieval bell tower that has presided over the city since the 13th century. You can climb it. You should climb it. There are *366 steps*, the staircase narrows alarmingly as you go up, and there are official passing places where you flatten yourself against the wall to let the descending people squeeze past. We did it on the second morning, queued for about twenty minutes at the base, and then puffed our way up through the bell chamber (the carillon is genuinely loud if you time it badly) to the open-air platform at the top. The view is the whole of medieval Bruges spread out below you, terracotta roofs and church spires and the green ribbon of canals threading through it. Worth every breathless step.

Day 1

Burg Square & the Basilica of the Holy Blood

One street east of the Markt sits the **Burg**, a smaller, more intimate square that holds Bruges's civic heart — the Gothic City Hall (one of the oldest in the Low Countries) and, tucked into a corner you could easily walk past, the **Basilica of the Holy Blood**. It is a small, double-decker chapel: a plain Romanesque lower level and an extravagantly painted upper chapel reached by a wide stone staircase. The basilica is said to hold a relic of the blood of Christ, brought back from the Second Crusade in the 12th century, and on quiet weekday mornings a member of the brotherhood sits at a small table at the front while pilgrims approach one by one to touch the reliquary. We were not pilgrims, but we sat at the back for fifteen minutes and watched, and the atmosphere of unhurried, lived medieval faith was unlike anything else we encountered in Belgium.

By 6 p.m. the last coach has groaned out of the car park, and Bruges deflates back into itself. The canals turn silver, the lanes empty, lamplight flickers on the gables — and the city you came to see finally appears.

Day 1

A Canal Boat, the Beguinage & the Lake of Love

The half-hour **canal boat ride** is touristy and entirely worth doing. Tickets sell on the spot at several jetties scattered around the centre; we paid roughly twelve euros each, queued briefly, and were on the water within twenty minutes. The boats are small, the guides crack the same jokes they have been cracking for thirty years, and you get the angle on Bruges that the city was originally designed to be seen from — water level, looking up at back gardens, brick water gates, and willow branches trailing onto the surface. Afterwards we walked south to the **Beguinage**, a serene white-walled compound of 13th-century houses around a central courtyard of daffodils (in season — in October it is mossy grass and tall trees). It was founded as a community of lay religious women and is now home to Benedictine nuns; visitors are asked to keep their voices low, and almost everyone does. Just beyond it is the **Minnewater**, the *Lake of Love*, a small willow-fringed pond with swans on it, which is exactly as photogenic as that description sounds.

Day 2

Chocolate, Waffles, Frites with Mayo

Belgium takes food seriously and Bruges takes it almost solemnly. Every third shop in the centre is a chocolatier, and the quality varies wildly — the boxes in the tourist windows on the main drags are often mediocre. The two names locals kept pointing us toward were **Dumon** (a tiny family operation with three small shops, the original one a wood-panelled jewel-box near the Markt) and **The Chocolate Line**, a more theatrical operation on Simon Stevinplein run by Dominique Persoone, the man who invented snortable cacao. We bought small mixed bags at both, ate them slowly on benches by the canal, and Dumon narrowly won our hearts on the strength of a salted-caramel praline that we are still thinking about. Waffles split into two camps — the dense, sugar-studded *Liège* style and the lighter, rectangular *Brussels* style — and we ate too many of both. The other obligatory snack is a paper cone of **frites with mayonnaise** from a frierie; the mayo is not optional and ketchup will mark you as an outsider.

Day 2

Trappist Beer & Why You Have to Stay Overnight

On our second evening we squeezed into **'t Brugs Beertje**, a famously cramped beer bar on a back street that stocks around 300 Belgian beers, and worked our way carefully through a list that included two Trappist ales (brewed by monks, only six abbeys worldwide allowed to use the label) and a sour Flemish red that tasted like cherry vinegar in the best possible way. The barman was patient, the wooden tables were sticky in a deeply convivial way, and we left after two hours feeling we had been properly inducted. Walking back to the hotel just before midnight, through completely empty lamplit streets with mist sitting on the canals and our footsteps echoing off the gables, we understood the single most important thing about visiting Bruges: *do not day-trip from Brussels*. The day trip gets you the Markt, the Belfort queue, and the coach park. Staying overnight gets you the city itself — the quiet hours after the buses leave and before they return, when Bruges turns back into a small Flemish town and lets you have it almost to yourself.

Must-Visit Places in Bruges

- **Belfort Tower (Markt)**: 366 steps, the best view of medieval Bruges.
- **Burg Square & Basilica of the Holy Blood**: Civic heart and a quiet upper chapel.
- **Canal Boat Ride**: Half an hour, water-level Bruges, worth the twelve euros.
- **The Beguinage**: Whitewashed courtyard, hush-yourself serene.

- **Minnewater (Lake of Love):** Swans, willows, end-of-walk reward.
- **Dumon & The Chocolate Line:** Skip the tourist boxes, buy from these two.
- **'t Brugs Beertje:** 300 Belgian beers, a tiny bar, a patient barman.
- **Bruges After Dark:** Walk the lanes after 9 p.m. — it is a different city.

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